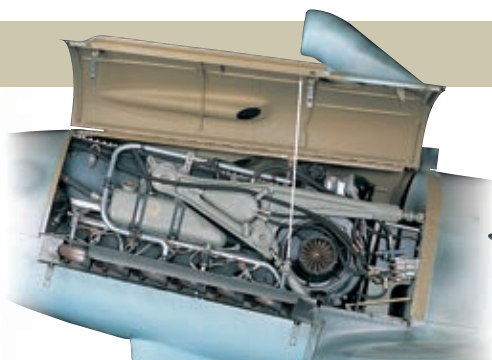




HIGH-POWERED ENGINE

The Bf 109E-3's Daimler-Benz DB 601Aa was a 12-cylinder inverted V-engine, hence the low position of the exhaust stubs. Inverting the engine left room for twin machine guns to be mounted above the crankcase.

of Britain. It was fast and maneuverable, although above 300mph (480kph) the controls became heavy. While it lacked the tight turning circle of the Spitfire, it was faster in a dive.

About 33,000 Bf 109s were built, a record for a military aircraft. By the end of the war they had been outclassed by more modern fighters, yet many Bf 109s remained in service with foreign air arms into the 1950s.



NARROW UNDERCARRIAGE

A narrow undercarriage coupled with a tendency for the plane to swing to port, led to some five percent of all Bf 109s being destroyed on takeoff and landing.

Slats in wing leading edge lift and delay stalling

Aperture for wing-mounted machine cannon

Cutoff switch

Gun sight with leather crash pad



Turn and bank indicator

Engine revolution counter

Gun button in top of control column

Specifications (E-3)

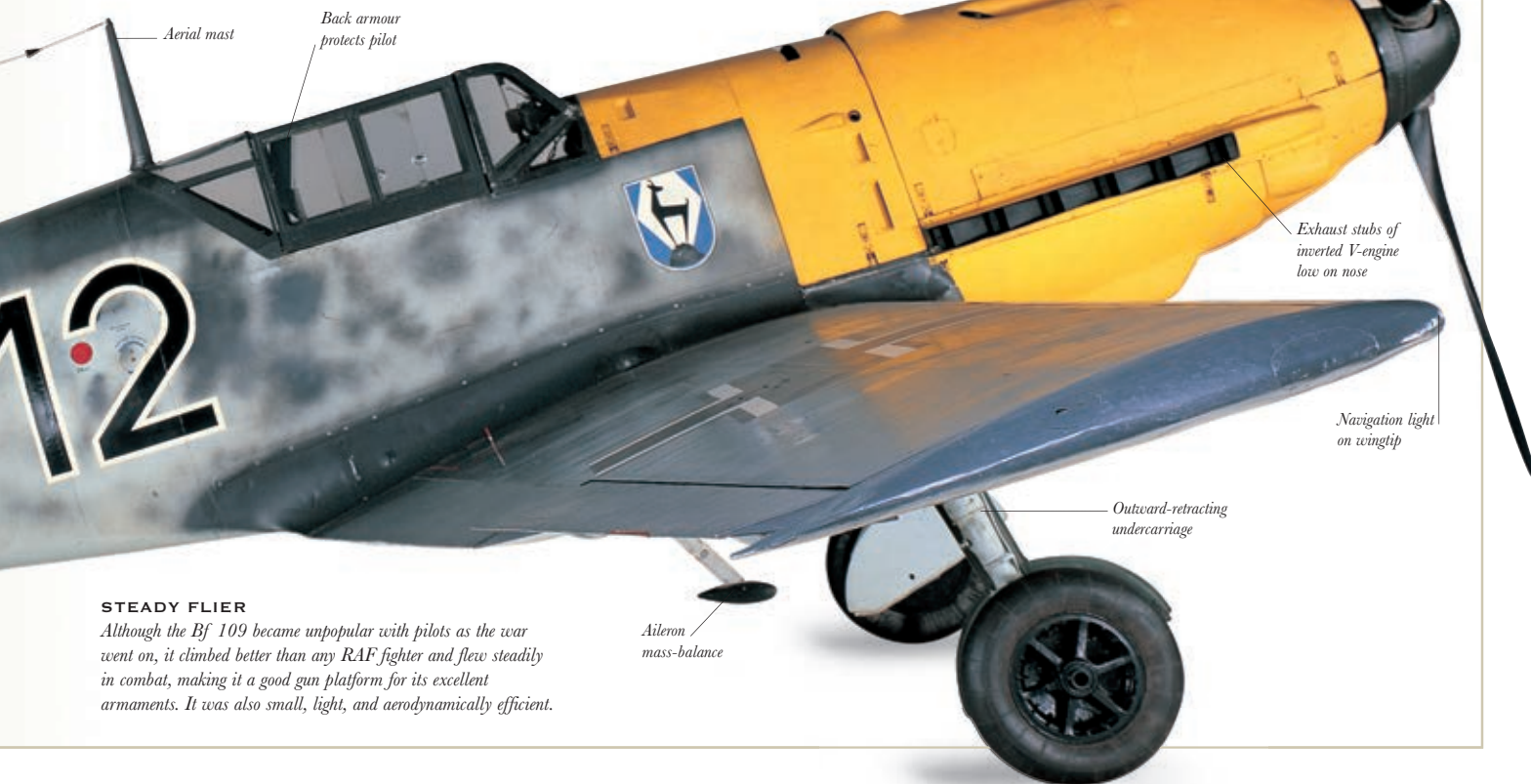
ENGINE 1,150hp 12-cylinder liquid-cooled Daimler-Benz 601Aa	
WINGSPAN 32ft 4in (9.8m)	
LENGTH 28ft 4in (8.6m)	
TOP SPEED 354mph (570kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 2 x 7.9mm MG 17 machine guns, 2 x 20mm MG FF cannon	

CRAMPED COCKPIT

The Bf 109's narrow, cramped, single-seat cockpit was enclosed by a sideways-opening canopy, which inhibited the pilot's vision and limited head movement.

Blast troughs for twin machine guns mounted on engine crankcase

Three-blade metal propeller



Exhaust stubs of inverted V-engine low on nose

Navigation light on wingtip

Outboard-retracting undercarriage

Aileron mass-balance

Back armour protects pilot

Aerial mast

STEADY FLIER

Although the Bf 109 became unpopular with pilots as the war went on, it climbed better than any RAF fighter and flew steadily in combat, making it a good gun platform for its excellent armaments. It was also small, light, and aerodynamically efficient.